I Need My Monster

By Amanda Knoll

ETHAN: Tonight, when I looked under the bed for my monster, I found this note instead: "Gone Fishing. Back in a week. –Gabe" What was I going to do? I ***needed*** a monster under my bed. How was I supposed to get to sleep if my monster was gone? I tried to sleep, but it wasn't the same with Gabe. I missed his ragged breathing *(Gabe – ragged breathing)* His nose-whistling. *(Gabe – nose whistles)* The scrabbling of his uncut claws. *(Gabe – Scrabbles his claws)* How would I ever get to sleep without Gabe's familiar scary noises and his spooky green ooze? *(Gabe – plays with his ooze)* It was no use. Gabe would be gone for a week and I just ***had*** to have a monster.

INTRODUCTION

Every night, kids across the globe worry that there's a monster hiding under the bed. It's a common fear that most adults can relate to—the fear of monsters isn't new. It's a fear that pre-dates video games and social media and has persisted throughout the generations. But for Ethan, his worry is that his monster ISN'T under his bed. I Need My Monster by Amanda Knoll turns this childhood fear on its head with humor and giggles and an assortment of substitute monsters!

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ETHAN: I climbed quietly out of bed so my parents wouldn't hear me. (Grown-ups have some strange ideas about monsters under beds.) I knocked on the floorboards, then scrambled back under my covers. I waited nervously. Would a new monster appear? What would he be like? Would his snorting be as cheerful as Gabe's? *(Creaking)* When I heard some creaking under my bed, I knew that the substitute monster had arrived.

HERBERT: *(a low, breathy voice)* Good evening. My name is Herbert and I will be your monster for the evening.

ETHAN: Herbert? What kind of name is that for a monster?! You don't sound scary at all. Have you ever scared a kid before?

HERBERT: Well, no, but I have read all the best books on the topic.

ETHAN: Do you have long teeth and scratchy claws?

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HERBERT: No, but I have an overbite. And I'm a mouth breather. Listen *(Herbert mouth breathes: hihi-huh, hih-huh, hih-huh, hih-huh)*

ETHAN: *(to audience)* Herbert's panting was ***kind*** of scary, but it wasn't enough for me. *(to Herbert)* Listen, Herbert, I'm sorry. I just don't think this is going to work. It's nothing personal, but I really need a monster with claws.

HERBERT: Picky, picky! As you wish. I'll go.

ETHAN: There was some more creaking. Then Herbert was gone. *(Scratching noises)* Some scratching warned me that a second monster had appeared.

RALPH: *(in a high, silky voice)* Good evening. My name is Ralph. I understand you need a monster with claws. If you would please lean over, I will hold out an arm for inspection.

ETHAN: I crouched on the edge of the bed, hoping to see a horrible shaggy arm with sharp, ragged nails. Instead, I was surprised to see sleekly brushed fur with smooth, shiny claws. *(To Ralph)* Excuse me, I don't mean to be rude, but is that nail polish on your claws?

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RALPH: Yes, it is. I believe professional monsters should always be well-groomed.

ETHAN: *(Heavy sigh)* I could tell that this was not going to work either. *(To Ralph)* I'm sorry to disappoint you, Ralph, but I need a monster with scary claws. *(To audience)* ***Like Gabe's.*** *(Scratching noises)* I heard some more scratching and I knew Ralph was gone.

CYNTHIA: *(Raspy voice)* Check out these claws, kid!

ETHAN: I gather my courage and peered over the edge. The claws were impressive – jagged and dark and razor-sharp. SO far, so good. I was a little nervous. *(To Cynthia in a whisper)* Could you stick out your tail?

CYNTHIA: Sure, but don't get scared!

ETHAN: I peeked through my fingers at the slimy tail slithering over the foot of my bed. That's when I noticed the bow. *(To Cynthia)* Are you a girl monster???

CYNTHIA: Of course I am. *(Snappishly)* I'm Cynthia. Do you have a problem with that?

ETHAN: Um, yeah, I do. I definitely need a ***boy*** monster. Boy monsters are for boys and girl monsters are for girls. Everybody knows that.

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CYNTHIA: *(Sniffing)* Well, aren't you a picky one! (Cynthia exits – be creative)

ETHAN: And then she was gone. ***Was*** I being too picky? NO! I knew that my monster needed to be well-clawed and menacing. The whole point of having a monster, after all, was to keep me in bed, imagining all the scary stuff that could happen if I got out. *(Shuffling noises and slobbering)* A fourth monster was under my bed.

MACK: Hey. The name's Mack. *(Extending his claws from under the bed)*

ETHAN: One look at his claws proved that Mack was a big, scruffy BOY monster. I shivered. Maybe this one would work out. *(To Mack)* Those are excellent claws, but do you have a long tail? *(Ethan leans over the bed to see)*

MACK: *(Slurping)* No, my tail is stumpy. But I do have an unu-u-u-usually lo-o-o-ong . . . tongue!

ETHAN: Why would I be afraid of a long tongue?

MACK: *(Trying to sound terrifying)* Oh, I don't know . . . You never know when I-I-I mi-i-i-ight . . . ***lick you!***

ETHAN: *(erupts into laugher)*

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MACK: *(Whining)* Well, if you're not even going to try-y-y-to work with me . . . *(Ethan tries to stop laughing)* I re-e-e-eally don't think you should send me away. Kids who reject five monsters in one night

ETHAN: *(Interrupting)* I did NOT reject five monsters tonight! My regular monster went fishing.

MACK: Fishing, eh? Maybe he just left because you're SO-O-O picky. Fine. I'm out of here. But I wouldn't expect another monster tonight if I were you. *(Mack exits – be creative)*

ETHAN: *(looks around his room. Looks under the bed. Tries to sleep but can't. Sits up)* How was I ever going to get to sleep without my monster? I was surprised to hear more creaking under the bed. *(Loud creaking and scratching) (To the monster under the bed)* I – I thought no more monsters were going to appear tonight.

GABE: Sorry I'm late, kid

ETHAN: *(To audience)* Whew. It was Gabe.

GABE: I thought I would enjoy fishing, but I didn't. Those fish scare too easily. No challenge at all. You, however, are challenging, my friend. You're almost

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too old to be afraid of monsters. You keep me on my toes. . . Ah, toes . . . a delicious snack. *(Gabe's stomach rumbles with hunger)* Now, if you don't mind, I'd like to start the evening with an ominous puddle of drool.

ETHAN: I peeked over the edge of the bed. Green ooze spread soundlessly from underneath. Then the bed trembled as Gabe unfurled his spiked tail. He was daring me to guess where he might pop up. *(Shivers)*

GABE: So, you had some substitute monsters tonight. *(Sharpening his claws on the bedpost)* Were you . . . . scaaaaaared? *(Gabe taps his claws impatiently on the bedpost)*

ETHAN: When Gabe started tapping, I could tell he wanted to know if I still needed him. No other monster can scare me like you! *(Giggling and diving under the covers, pulling them up tight)*

GABE: *(Soft, comforting snorts then growling)* Ha! I knew it! We're made for each other. *(Gabe begins to pull the blanket off the bed)* Now, if you could please stick out your foot . . . I'd like to nibble your pinkie.

ETHAN: *(yanking the blanket back up and scrunching his feet in so Gabe can't get them)* No toes tonight, but

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you can have this! *(pushes a pillow off the bed) (To audience)* I didn't even hear it hit the floor. Gabe was back. The ooze was perfect. Everything was back to normal. *(Shivering again)* I'd be asleep in no time.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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